

Lecture 14: Culture is Ordinary

Introduction

- Cultural studies
- Emerged from a critical dialogue between the cultural theory of Leavisism and classical Marxism.
- Foundational texts in this tradition include the works of Richard Hoggart, Raymond Williams, and E. P. Thompson, published in the late 1950s and early 1960s.
- A central theme uniting their work is an emphasis on human agency

Origins

- British Cultural Studies emerges in the post-war period, roughly from the late 1950s onward.
- Britain at this point is undergoing a profound transformation. The Second World War has ended, the welfare state is expanding, higher education is no longer the preserve of a tiny elite, and mass media is becoming a dominant force in everyday life.
- This is a Britain in which class still matters enormously, but its cultural forms are changing. Traditional working-class communities are being reshaped by urban redevelopment, consumer capitalism, and new forms of entertainment such as television, popular music, advertising.
- Up until this point, culture had often been treated in one of two unsatisfactory ways. On the one hand, in elite literary traditions, culture meant “high culture” Shakespeare, opera, classical music — something refined, elevated, and clearly separated from everyday life. On the other hand, in some forms of Marxism, culture was treated as little more than a reflection of the economic base – Marx / Frankfurt school.
- British Cultural Studies rejects both positions. Instead, it argues that culture is ordinary, lived, contested, and deeply political.

- Rejection of cultural pessimism on the one hand, and cultural celebration on the other.
- Cultural Studies is not simply about analysing films or music for their own sake. It is about understanding culture as a site of struggle.
- Shaped by the expansion of adult education and working-class access to universities in post-war Britain.
- Crystallises with the founding of the Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies, or CCCS, at the University of Birmingham in 1964. CCCS becomes a intellectual hub for a new, interdisciplinary approach.

E. P. Thompson and the Foundations of Cultural Studies

- Thompson's historical sociology profoundly shaped how culture, class, and power came to be understood within the field.
- His insistence on lived experience, historical specificity, and human agency provided a crucial alternative to structuralist and economic approaches, influencing generations of scholars concerned with culture as a site of struggle rather than mere reflection.

Culture as Lived Experience

History from Below and Cultural Agency

Moral Economy and Cultural Conflict

Raymond Williams: Culture and Society

- Rather than treating culture as the preserve of art, literature, or intellectual achievement, Williams famously insisted that culture should be understood as a "whole way of life."
- For Williams, culture encompassed everyday practices, values, institutions, meanings, and forms of communication through which social life is organised. This shift made it possible to study popular culture, media, and ordinary social experience as serious objects of analysis rather than as degraded or secondary forms.

- Williams developed this position most clearly in *Culture and Society* (1958)
- Pre-emergent cultural experiences of a class not yet articulated in formal ideology
- Culture was not a timeless category but a contested concept shaped by specific historical struggles.
- A key feature of Williams's work is his resistance to determinism. While he was deeply influenced by Marxism, he rejected versions that treated culture as a simple reflection of economic structures.
- One of Williams's most influential conceptual contributions is the idea of "structure of feeling." This concept was developed to capture social experiences that are lived and felt but not yet fully articulated in formal institutions or dominant ideologies. Structures of feeling refer to shared, emergent ways of sensing and understanding the world that arise during periods of social change.
- In works such as *Communications* (1962) and *Television: Technology and Cultural Form* (1974), he challenged technological determinism, particularly the view that media technologies themselves dictate social outcomes. Instead, he argued that technologies are developed and used within specific social and political contexts.
- His concept of "flow" in television analysis demonstrated how broadcasting operates as a continuous sequence rather than a series of discrete programmes, shaping how audiences experience media in everyday life. This approach treated media as embedded in social relations rather than as neutral tools or autonomous forces.
- The concept of flow also has implications for how meaning is produced. Because television is experienced as a sequence, meanings emerge cumulatively rather than in isolation

Richard Hoggart (1918-) (see slides)

Stuart Hall

- Draws heavily on the Italian Marxist Antonio Gramsci, particularly the concept of hegemony.
- Hegemony refers to the process by which dominant groups secure consent rather than relying purely on force. Power works not just through laws or police, but through common sense through ideas that feel natural, inevitable, and beyond question.
- 1973 essay “Encoding and Decoding in the Television Discourse.” In this model, Hall rejected the idea that media messages have fixed meanings that are simply transmitted to audiences.
- Encoding and decoding. This model challenges the idea that media messages have fixed meanings that are simply transmitted to passive audiences. Dominant (hegemonic), negotiated, oppositional (see model)
- In ‘The Whites of Their Eyes: Racist Ideologies and the Media’ Hall talks about ‘grammar of racism’ on television and encoding ‘Love Thy Neighbour’ - was based around a white working class couple (Eddie and Joan Booth) living in Twickenham, in the outer London suburbs, and a black couple (Bill and Barbie Reynolds) as their next-door neighbours
- *Policing the Crisis: Mugging, the State, and Law and Order* (1978), authored by Stuart Hall and colleagues at the Birmingham Centre for Contemporary Cultural Studies (CCCS), is one of the most influential works in British cultural studies and critical sociology.
- How a relatively limited phenomenon, a moral panic, street robbery, labelled as “mugging” became a major political and moral issue in 1970s Britain.
- Media, policing, and state power interact to produce ideological responses to wider social and economic crises.